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# Decline, adaptation and relevance: political parties and their researchers in the twentieth century

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## Abstract
The sub-field of political party research is an interesting case study of the broader development of the discipline of political science over the past 20 years as it demonstrates the reflexive and evolving relationship between politics researchers and the organizations that they study. Party research has moved on from crises of existence, to studying the resilience and adaptation of these organizations with new and evolving methodologies that have taken party research into the twenty-first century and fostered more collaborative, specialist and increasingly internationalized relationships within the research community. In the last two decades, expectations around research engagement and impact have heightened in response to changes in the research funding environment and the political pressure to demonstrate the ongoing relevance of the discipline has intensified. The increasingly heterogeneous, specialized and quantified nature of the subfield has enabled party scholarship to find impact and relevance through the provision of technical advice to parties and policymakers, thereby affecting how parties organize. However, while political party researchers have been able to engage audiences outside academia with this specialized and technical advice, the sub-discipline has shifted away from some of the "bigger picture", normative questions surrounding the role of parties in modern representative democracies.

**Keywords** Methods · Party change · Party research · Political parties · Research field history

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## Introduction

The sub-field of political party research is an interesting case study of the broader development of the discipline of political science over the past 20 years as it demonstrates the reflexive and evolving relationship between politics researchers and the organizations that they study. As we will show in this article, the concerns of party researchers—like parties themselves—have moved on from crises of existence, to studying the resilience and adaptation of these organizations with new and evolving methodologies that have taken party research into the twenty-first century and fostered more collaborative, specialist and increasingly internationalized relationships within the research community. Fewer general monographs and more journal articles dealing with a limited number of party organizational characteristics are published, and while qualitative research methods have not disappeared, they have given way to more quantitative studies. In the last two decades, expectations around research engagement and impact have heightened in response to changes in the research funding environment and the pressure to demonstrate the ongoing relevance of the discipline has intensified. This is evident, for example, in the introduction of impact case studies as an integral part of the UK's Research Framework Exercise (REF) to measure research quality, significance and reach. Evaluating the Horizon 2020 Research Program, the European Research Council also noted the need for funding to create more impact through mission-oriented research and citizen involvement (EC 2018). We argue that the increasingly heterogeneous, specialized and quantified nature of the subfield has enabled party scholarship to find impact and relevance through the provision of technical advice to parties and policymakers. On this basis, scholars are able to affect how parties organize and provide the essential linkage between people and elected representatives. However, while political party researchers have been able to engage audiences outside academia with this specialized and technical advice, the sub-discipline has shifted away from some of the "bigger picture", normative questions surrounding the role of parties in modern representative democracies.

The article proceeds in two sections. First, we review the main trends in the nature of party research over the last 20 years, with a focus on the "European tradition". While this fits with the focus of the 20 years of EPS special issue, it also reflects the fact that both the development of political parties—and hence the nature of party research—have followed two very different paths in Europe and the USA. The study of parties in the USA (and American parties themselves) has traditionally been regarded as exceptional (see for example, Ware 2011)—owing to the relatively weak nature of political parties as organizations—which means that the study of party politics in the USA has been largely subsumed within studies of voter and legislative behaviour. The European tradition, which places a far greater emphasis on the party as an independent and powerful political organization, has influenced scholarship in other regions and countries, including Canada, Australia, New Zealand and South East Asia. We point to three main trends that we see as characteristic of the development of the sub-field and discipline: the shift to increasingly comparative, team-based methodologies, an increase

in specializations within the sub-field (for example, party leadership, candidate nomination and membership), and the increasing use of large datasets that can build on existing data or pair with complementary projects, which has enabled the application of quantitative methods to a larger extent.

The second part of the article examines the impact and engagement agenda of party research. First, we outline some of the ways in which the specialist and "technical" expertise of party scholars is utilized to provide advice for governments and international organizations. Second, we examine the engagement between party researchers and the subjects of their study—political parties themselves—in terms of the provision of advice and consultancy services to help parties identify goals and achieve reforms. We provide examples of where parties and researchers have worked together collaboratively and outline some of the challenges and opportunities of securing access and maintaining productive working relationships. The field of party research is a vibrant one that includes hundreds of scholars working across Europe and beyond. Because of this, we cannot hope to cover all of the excellent work that is being done—our general examples serve as illustrations only—and while they are intended to be broad, they are limited by our own expertise and experience.

## Trends in party research

The characteristics of political party research as a sub-discipline of political science reflect, and have evolved with, changes in the nature of the organizations that it studies. In the 1980s, 1990s and into the first decade of the twenty-first century, the dominant paradigm that framed the study of political parties as policy makers and organizers of representative and participatory politics was one of decline. The title of Lawson and Merkl's (1988) edited volume, *When Parties Fail: Emerging Alternative Organizations*, perfectly captured the quest to understand why political parties had failed and to explore the universe of alternate political organizations and movements that were to take their place. The decline of political parties was also a prominent research theme in cognate fields—for example, scholars of electoral behaviour documented the decline of political parties via decreasing voter turnout, partisanship and trust (see, e.g. Clarke and Stewart 1998; Dalton and Wattenberg 2000; Dalton and Weldon 2005), while the broader field of political participation highlighted a shift in citizens' preferences away from formal political institutions (such as parties) towards more fluid and issues-based forms of political engagement (Norris 2002; Dalton 2008).

This rather nihilistic approach marked a substantial shift away from the "classic" earlier works in political sociology and political science that examined power relations within political parties (e.g. Ostrogorski 1903; Michels 1911; Duverger 1951), their modus operandi (e.g. Kirchheimer 1966; Panebianco 1988) and understanding of how they structured political systems (Sartori 1976; Mair 1990). While these works were often critical of the performance of parties, particularly in matters concerning their internal organization, the place of parties in representative democracies seemed assured. So much so that the mid-twentieth century is often referred to as the "golden age" of parties (Scarrow 2015; Katz and Mair 1995). The

methodological orientation of many of these studies was either an in-depth analysis of single case or a comparative qualitative analysis of a relatively small number of parties. Research was concerned with how parties organized, the diversity of forms they took, and the effect they had on citizens' attitudes and voters' preferences (see Gauja and Kosiara-Pedersen 2021). Scholars often engaged with broader normative questions concerning the role and function of parties in politics, with particularly vibrant debates around the desirability—and practicality—of intra-party democracy as a means of realizing a genuine connection between citizens and the state (see, for example, Michels 1911; Duverger 1951; McKenzie 1963).

Travelling forward from the "golden age" of political parties, and through the period where scholars were convinced of their decline, the late 1990s and early 2000s again marked a shift in party scholarship to an approach that centred on party adaptation. In 1997, a special issue of the journal *Party Politics* was published that specifically examined party change. The editors described their motivation as follows: "after a few decades observing some parties "decline" then "renew", it was perhaps natural that more attention…be focused on how they got from there to here" (Harmel and Svåsand 1997: 291). Two years prior, party scholars Richard Katz and Peter Mair had published their highly influential "cartel party thesis" (Katz and Mair 1995), which suggested that in order to ensure their survival, political parties had become firmly embedded in, and reliant on, the resources of the state. Parties resembled one another more and more in policy terms, working in concert to reduce democratic competition. As parties continued to exist, party research changed direction to examine their resilience, adaptation and transformation. Like the organizations it studied, party scholarship continued to evolve.

This agenda of adaptation and survival has continued to shape the character of party research in the twenty years since the first issue of *EPS* was published. From the cartel thesis onwards, scholars have analysed the transformation of parties in response to declining memberships (see, for example, Scarrow 2015), changing technologies and campaign practices (e.g. Gerbaudo 2019; Gibson et al. 2017) and social and cultural shifts, such as personalized (e.g. Rahat and Kenig 2018) and populist politics (e.g. Albertazzi and McDonnell 2015). Along with this shift in emphasis to party adaptation, the methods, approaches and techniques used by party scholars have also evolved.

## Comparative, team-based methodologies

Party research has traditionally been dominated by country (or regional) experts. The empirical basis of party documents such as party statutes, speech transcripts and election manifestos, as well as interviews, has required some level of language knowledge. Together with Janda (1980), the Katz and Mair project on how parties organized laid a central cornerstone for the renewal of interest in party research due to the wealth of data and publications it generated (Katz and Mair 1992a, 1994, 1995, 2018), including a number of country studies (Katz and Mair 1994; Bille 1997) and some comparative analyses (Bille 2001; Pierre et al. 2000). Perhaps even more importantly, the Katz and Mair project established a collaborative, comparative

project design that continues to guide best practice in party research today. It did so by collecting a group of country experts around a common theme/research question to pave the way for genuine collaboration. In this case, party statutes provided the backbone for the data collection and one of the main contributions of the project was to point to the importance of this "official story" of the parties, since statutes provided the framework for organization and are referred to if disagreement occurs. A further advantage of statutes is that they enable comparisons over time and across parties and countries.

Katz and Mair explained the goal behind their team-based approach to data collection, synthesis and analysis was that "once having established the official story", there was a need to "move beyond it by adding politics to the raw data, and hence to understand the context in which parties develop their organization structures and the reasons why they change or remain the same" (1994: vi). Assembling a team of country experts to work together secured the utility of this approach, and enabled the project to traverse both the need for generalization with the depth of understanding that typically characterizes single-case studies:

> …the authors of these chapters were themselves responsible for the original data collection, and so they are particularly sensitive to what these data mean within the different national contexts and to how they should be interpreted. In this sense they are very well placed to offer what might be called the "real [national] story" (1994: vi).

While some pioneering comparative analyses came out of this project, the data were not easily accessible due to the character of the database, which was published as a printed volume (Katz and Mair 1992b). Building on the main premise of the Katz and Mair project model, and adapting it to the twenty-first century, country experts, cross-country comparative analyses and transparent data accessibility lie at the heart of the Political Parties Database Project (PPDB). Initiated by renowned party scholar Susan Scarrow and two of the country experts from the original Katz and Mair project, Thomas Poguntke and Paul Webb, the first two rounds of collaborative data collection in occurred in 2011–2012 and 2017, facilitated by international workshops, as well as online survey and team-based productivity platforms (Google docs and Qualtrics). This mode of working enabled the expansion of data collection across the world, and the dataset includes more than 250 parties in 42 countries, providing data on a variety of organizational aspects based upon statutes, web sites, information from party headquarters, laws and public statistics. The PPDB itself allows for general analyses of how parties organize and the effect of this (Poguntke et al. 2016; Scarrow et al. 2017) but is also well suited for combination with other country, party and individual-level data (e.g. Achury et al. 2020).

The Katz and Mair and PPDB projects provide two examples of a collaborative mode of research design that has transformed comparative research in the discipline. Not only has this model balanced breath of coverage with depth of expertise, it has provided for genuine collaborative data collection and analysis from teams of scholars that secure geographic, gender, methodological and career-age diversity. For example, of the country experts contributing to the PPDB project, utilizing various online applications and software, has enabled cooperation across borders without

demanding international mobility—a mode of working that is now more important than ever. It is perhaps taking political science closer to the natural sciences, evidenced by the foundational publication from the PPDB project, a co-authored journal article with 23 contributing authors (Poguntke et al. 2016).

## Specializations within party research

With the increasing availability of data and interest in the evolution of political parties, the field has also seen an expansion in specialized topics within the sub-field. We now have groups of scholars who work on the different types of political parties (for example, digital parties, populist parties, cartel parties, green parties), different functions of parties (policy, political recruitment, campaigning) and different features of party organization (membership, candidate selection, leadership selection). This list is by no means exhaustive, but it does illustrate the tendency of scholars to increasingly focus on specialized questions and practices, which does create the danger of a fragmented sub-discipline and may potentially abstract current research from the bigger normative questions that concerned scholars in the past. This is in part mitigated by the tendency of many colleagues to work in multiple specializations, and by the fact that many of these specializations overlap. It does, however, reinforce the continued need for more generalist academic events and conversations—such as those that have been facilitated within the discipline by the European Consortium for Political Research (ECPR) Standing Group on Political Parties, the Parties Summer School and the UK Political Science Association (PSA) specialist group on Elections, Public Opinion and Parties.

The study of membership provides one example of a specialization that has embraced international collaboration. Since the expansion of the electorate and golden days of mass parties, party membership has been a central component of party research. Party headquarters have provided more or less reliable membership figures enabling analyses of the size of membership organizations and hence an indication of party linkage with the electorate beyond election day (Katz and Mair 1992a; Scarrow 2000; Mair and van Biezen 2001; van Biezen et al. 2012; van Haute et al. 2018). However, the questions of who members are, why they enrol, how representative they are of party electorates and why they engage in politics were not answered prior to the advent of party membership studies as a specialization within the field of party research (Seyd and Whiteley 1992). While the beginning was slow with some parties (Whiteley et al. 1994; Gallagher and Marsh 2002) and countries (Allern et al. 2016; Heidar 1994; den Ridder et al. 2015; Pedersen et al. 2004), party member studies have certainly picked up (van Haute and Gauja 2015). Through cooperation and coordination, the field has expanded from studies of single parties (possibly even in single regions) or single countries, to complex comparative projects utilizing existing national surveys (Pedersen and Saglie 2005; Heidar and Kosiara-Pedersen 2006; Heidar et al. 2012; Demker et al. 2019; Heidar and Wauters 2019). The "Members and Activists of Political Parties' (MAPP) project (see www.projectmapp.eu) has taken party member studies to a new level. Led by Emilie van Haute, the MAPP project assembled a team of country experts who conducted a

joint and collaboratively designed membership survey in countries with, and without, a tradition for party member surveys. In a similar vein, Elin H. Allern gathered country experts and fielded national surveys to study the relationship between political parties and interest groups (PAIRDEM.org). Other specialist research endeavours include comparative team-based projects on party leadership (Pilet and Cross 2014, 2016; Cross and Blais 2012a,b) and party competition (ICCP, https://cise.luiss.it/iccp/index.php/publications/).

### Combinations of datasets

The final trend in the evolution of party research methods and approaches, which is a feature of the team-based projects that we have described above, is the creation and distribution of large, comparative datasets on various aspects of political parties. Making these data publicly available has enhanced the transparency of party research and extended its reach beyond the immediate sub-discipline with scholars from other subfields of political science, for example, electoral behaviour, combining comparative party data with other existing datasets (Döring and Regel 2020). This has enabled researchers to examine, for example, party competition and interest group ties (Allern et al. 2020), the link between party organization and policy positions (Ogawa et al. 2019), the relationship between state funding and party responsiveness (Costa Lobo and Razzuoli 2017) and whether enrolment criteria and party members' rights and obligations are related to the number and participation of party members (Kosiara-Pedersen et al. 2017).

## The "real-world impact" of party research

Through intellectual inquiry, party research potentially allows scholars to affect how parties organize and provide the essential linkage between people and elected representatives. The challenge for party researchers has been to translate these disciplinary concerns into real-world impact. This challenge has become more acute in recent decades as competition for research funding intensifies and politicians have brought into question the value of political science as a discipline (see, for example, Mole 2013). In this section we examine three strategies party researchers have adopted and give some illustrative examples: advising governments, advising parties and collaborating with parties.

### Advising governments

Scholars advise governments and international organizations on party regulation—typically on party finance and party organization. The question of what parties do and how they organize are well-integrated into institutions that promote democratic development, such as IDEA, the National Democratic Institute (NDI) and the OSCE Office for Democratic Institutions and Human Rights. By providing advice on possible regulation and organization, party research allows the authorities in

democratizing states to carefully consider what role parties are to play and what legal framework will aid parties in organizing in a way that is deemed democratic. In newly democratized states such as the Central and Eastern European states, for example, party laws are used to counteract "lingering anti-democratic tendencies" (Karvonen 2007: 450–1).

Changes in the context and character of parties in established democracies also call for party research to enlighten governments on how to adjust the (legal) framework for political parties. The regulation of party financing seems to be the most important lever that states have to influence how parties organize. While parties were initially seen as private organizations, the advent of public party financing has led to more regulation of party incomes and expenses. However, compared to interest groups, charities and trade unions, political parties are privileged as they receive a significant amount of public funding (van Biezen and Kopecky 2017) but are to a much smaller extent subject to transparency requirements, governance arrangements and administrative accountability mechanisms (Bolleyer 2018; Gauja 2016). If a government—or a parliamentary majority—is truly interested in creating transparency and accountability, party research provides both a necessary understanding of how parties organize and what measures are taken elsewhere. Party scholars are often called on to provide such advice. For example, the OSCE has established a core group of Experts on Political Parties (www.osce.org/odihr), comprised of prominent party researchers, to provide expert advice to governments on matters concerning party regulation. These experts were instrumental in drafting, and now revising, the Venice Commission's Guidelines on Political Party Regulation (OSCE 2011). When the Danish government wanted to ensure a larger degree of transparency in party financing (as called for also by EU's GRECO) in 2014, their expert committee included both a law professor with expertise in party regulation and a political scientist studying parties, and the combination of their research-based expertise with people from the state administration resulted in a feasible model for more transparency (Justitsministeriet 2015).

## Advising parties

The second way in which party research allows scholars to affect how parties organize and provide the essential linkage between people and elected representatives is by inspiring and advising parties on party reform. Political parties themselves are very well aware of the changing conditions in which they work and see how the conditions for e.g. financing, membership and candidate recruitment changes. Recent party research points to a larger similarity within rather than across countries, which indicate the importance of the national context and that parties compete within the same electorate (Scarrow et al. 2017; Poguntke et al. 2016). However, parties also seek inspiration from outside, through exchange within their networks in transnational party organizations.

More importantly, parties' professionalization implies that at least some develop and change their organizational characteristics if not on the basis of, then at least inspired by, research. Parties, in particular the larger and more resourceful,

increasingly hire professionals within the realm of campaigning, mobilization and organization. They bring their academic knowledge into play but also seek inspiration from (national language) research, either by accessing national studies, commissioning researchers to undertake party-specific research or inviting them to give talks on specific aspects of their organizations that they are seeking to approve, for example on campaigning effects or the motivations of those seeking to join. Due to a stronger empirical base in terms of comparative reach and detail, party research is able to both depict the varied ways in which parties may organize but also, due to the increasing number of this kind of studies, point to the effect of various initiatives.

Increasingly volatile voter-party linkages and party membership decline have been problems for parties for a while (Katz and Mair et al. 1992a; Scarrow 2000; Mair and van Biezen 2001; van Biezen et al. 2012; van Haute et al. 2018). Declining membership figures have resulted, in some parties, in the individualization of member rights (Katz and Mair 1995; Bille 2001) in order to increase the benefits of party membership. However, more recently, parties have sought inspiration in how to expand the mobilization and engagement of their supporters. The subfield of party member research has provided solid responses to questions such as why members enrol and why they engage in party activism (see e.g. van Haute and Gauja 2015; Demker et al. 2019; Bale et al. 2019), but also how parties may expand their affiliation beyond members (Scarrow 2015; Gauja 2015) and whether opening up to other types of affiliation will harm their membership figures further (Kosiara-Pedersen et al. 2017; Achury et al. 2020). This wealth of research has recently been reflected in a series of "innovation primers" for political parties published by the International IDEA (https://www.idea.int/publications), utilizing party research findings to provide recommendations for membership, crowdfunding and online mobilization. Within countries, parties are interested in the results of the party member studies, as e.g. in the Danish case, where parties have asked for a presentation of the results and input on organizational development. In a similar vein, results of the ESRC-funded project on British Political Party members have been presented (by invitation) to the major British parties (https://esrcpartymembersproject.org/events/).

The advice given to political parties by researchers is characterized by the fact that it is given at arm's length, either mediated through international organizations or through a process of research dissemination that is targeted at multiple parties. The reason for this, and also why we do not observe many party scholars undertaking consultancies with individual parties, is the need to maintain scholarly independence and neutrality. To effectively study political parties, researchers need to maintain relationships with numerous parties across the political spectrum. Because of the nature of political competition, too close an engagement with one particular party might shut the door to opportunities with others.

## Accessing, engaging and collaborating with political parties

Party scholars may base their research on publicly accessible information, such as party statutes, manifestos and parliamentary behaviour. This "desk research" approach ensures a relatively easy access to data. However, much party research

is conducted "in the field", where the empirical analysis rests on the cooperation of the parties themselves. When scholars rely on, for example, interviews and data on membership, staff etc., the challenges and opportunities of securing access and maintaining productive working relationships with the parties become important.

Political parties are inherently competitive organizations. In the competition for votes, they may very well be reluctant to disclose any information that might compromise a perceived competitive advantage, including campaigning techniques and membership data. This is, of course, tempered by national cultural and political considerations, so variation across countries and parties exists in the extent to which parties want to collaborate on research.

Hence, on the one hand, parties are private organizations not keen on collaboration with scholars. British parties, for example, have not always been keen on collaboration, and hence, some party member studies have been carried out without their participation, or with limited cooperation (Whiteley et al. 1994; Bale et al. 2019). In the first comprehensive membership study of the UK Conservatives, Seyd and Whitely faced resistance from local party officers who refused to provide necessary data, leading to adjustments in the survey methodology. The researchers believed this lack of access was due to intra-party politics—the fierce autonomy of local Conservative associations and suspicions over the role of head office in the research, but also a refusal to hand over information to outsiders (Whiteley et al. 1994: 239–240). When Tim Bale, Paul Webb and Monica Poletti undertook their study of British party members almost three decades later, they circumvented parties altogether—working with a market research company to field their surveys to members. This gave the researchers "complete freedom to ask them [party members] whatever questions we wanted to ask—and without the nagging fear that one or other of the parties would change their mind and veto the project at the last minute" (Bale et al. 2019: 2).

While circumventing the party may be a feasible strategy for gaining data at first, it could endanger the prospect of future collaboration with these (and other) parties, particularly if information is released that is not favourable to the parties concerned. Cooperation is possible. Some parties are keen to collaborate because of the insights external expert research brings. If not positive at first, cooperation requires that party scholars are able to develop a trustful relationship with parties. Parties need to know that the data will not be used for tabloid headlines, that the analyses are conducted in a scientifically solid way, and that researchers can be trusted not to convey knowledge to other parties, harming any competitive advantage. Like much quality research this takes time and effort, but it is possible to develop a good relationship.

This is exemplified by Project MAPP, in which many participating researchers have managed to convince political parties of the fruitfulness of participating in party member surveys. While some parties, for example the Danish (Kosiara-Pedersen 2017), engage without reservation, securing cooperation will in other countries and parties involve a process of negotiation and compromise on issues such as the timing of the research and any fieldwork in the party, the nature of the research questions and the possible participants (for example, party members, officials or members), as e.g. seen in the Belgian case. In the best cases this will lead to robust, codesigned project that benefits both academic researchers and

political parties. Key challenges however are threat of withdrawal, questions that are not suitable and/or politically motivated and limited access to potential participants within the party. In the question for relevance and good research co-design, these challenges are often worth navigating—yet the reality is that often they cannot be overcome, and alternative research designs need to be found.

The impact of the extent of parties' cooperation on what party research can be done depends on the availability of alternative sources of data. For example, the Iceland election studies include a sufficient number of party members to analyse these; hence, collaboration with the parties is less needed (Önnudóttir and Björnsdóttir 2014). In a similar vein, party members' characteristics may for large parties be assessed on the basis of large, cross-national surveys of social attitudes (Ponce and Scarrow 2016; Scarrow and Gezgor 2010). Creativity may be also needed, for example, when physical phonebooks published annually provide an indication of each party's number of parliamentary staff, and when the (list) prize of ads and commercials is used as a crude measure of parties' campaign spending.

The broader implication of limited access and cooperation for research is that some parties and countries are not included in (some of) the comparative research projects. The original Katz and Mair (1992b) database of party organization, for example, only included the parties of Western European democracies. The Political Parties Database Project has extended this geographic spread over time, to include a range of countries from Central and Eastern Europe, North and South America and Asia (Poguntke et al. 2016). However, the global reach of political party studies is far from complete and there is much work to do in future studies to understand the diversity of political parties in all countries, particularly those not considered established or emerging democracies.

Beyond the inclusion of countries, there is also the question of obtaining a representative or meaningful diversity of parties. While missing single parties may not create any problems, particularly if the party is "common" or mainstream (e.g. social democratic parties), there is a pattern in the types of political parties that refuse to cooperate with researchers—for example, e.g. radical right-wing parties (Kölln and Polk 2015), locally based parties (the Norwegian Coastal Party, cf. Heidar 1994) or "special issue" parties (den Ridder et al. 2015). The consequence is that party research does lack analytic power in investigating certain types of parties, which may in turn skew more general assessments of the health of parties and frame our expectations of how parties organize in alignment with progressive parties, which open their organizations up to greater academic scrutiny. When all parties within a country decline to participate in scholarly research, the implications for the scholarly results are potentially more severe. In Australia, for example, only the Green Party has provided accurate membership figures, so researchers have no way of knowing definitively how many citizens have joined these organizations. More importantly, missing parties and countries have serious societal implications. With little access to parties, scholars are unable to provide the basis for their democratic accountability. Parties have a near monopoly on getting candidates elected; hence, control the channels of political recruitment, and they are central in campaigning and formulating policy.

## Conclusion and challenges ahead

In our review of the main trends in the nature of party research over the last 20 years, with a focus on the "European tradition", we point to three main trends that we see as characteristic of the development of the sub-field and discipline: First, the shift to increasingly comparative, team-based methodologies; second, an increase in specializations within the sub-field (for example, party leadership, candidate nomination and membership); and third, the increasing use of large datasets that can build on existing data or pair with complementary projects, which has enabled the application of quantitative methods to a larger extent. This wealth of party research within the last 20 years provides the basis for party scholars' provision of specialist and "technical" expertise and advice to governments and international organizations as well as parties themselves. Some party research relies on collaboration with parties, and this provides both challenges and opportunities, since not all parties grant access to the kind of data, on e.g. party staff, party membership and party financing, some studies rely on.

While party researchers are able to achieve significant relevance with the specialized and "technical" advice on, e.g. party financing, affiliation and candidate recruitment, the discipline has shifted away from some of the "bigger picture" questions surrounding the role of political parties in modern representative democracies. The challenges facing parties are facing party research as well.

One of these challenges is how to involve people in the process of interest aggregation and policy formulation. Parties' membership organizations have to some extent been emptied of policy development with the centralization and professionalization; power has moved towards the party elite, party staff and possibly the parliamentary party. We see a surge in deliberative fora on current topics such as the abortion referendum in Ireland and climate action in Denmark. What is the role of parties if not to address and provide answers to the most pressing and recurrent problems facing our societies? In the scholarly domain, the challenge for the profession is to identify and address the research questions that "matter" and that impact upon the healthy functioning of our societies. Addressing these questions with scientific vigour, but with maximum participation from political actors and communities is a high priority.

A second challenge we would like to emphasize is that parties dominate candidate nomination and have a de facto monopoly on parliamentary representation. With fewer and fewer party members, the recruitment pool dwindles, and an insignificant share of voters decide whom all other voters may vote for, unless the parties upon up for primaries. The smaller membership base may become even more skewed if branches are not upholding the kind of activities that train and provide resources for those less inclined to self-nominate, which are also the underrepresented (in particular women). And this is also a challenge for the academy and the discipline. While we see more women represented in the field (for example, 36% of the country experts involved in the Political Parties Database Project are women), we have not reached gender parity. Party research must

ensure that various perspectives are integrated and represented to ensure the best possible research design and outcomes.

Political parties are signs of the time. But the time in which they were created is more important for how they organize (Katz and Mair 1995) than the current time. While the field of party research is evolving it must continue to look to the future and think beyond disciplinary silos. It is up to party research to point towards how party organizations can provide linkage between the elected and the people—and the policy responses to the challenging issues of our time.

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